1. Purpose

This policy describes when Alderpoint Health Plan covers magnetic resonance imaging (MRI) of the lumbar spine for low back pain.

2. Definitions

Supervised home exercise program: a program prescribed by a clinician or therapist with documented follow-up of the member's participation, such as a signed exercise log or follow-up visits.

Conservative therapy: non-surgical treatment, including physical therapy, exercise, and medication.

3. Coverage criteria

3.1 Low back pain with or without leg symptoms. MRI of the lumbar spine is medically necessary when all of the following are documented:

(a) Symptoms have been present for at least 6 weeks.

(b) The member completed at least 6 weeks of physical therapy or a supervised home exercise program within the 3 months before the request.

(c) The member completed a trial of an anti-inflammatory or analgesic medication for at least 4 weeks, unless contraindicated.

(d) A clinical re-evaluation after conservative therapy documents persistent symptoms.

3.2 Red-flag exception. Criteria 3.1(a) through 3.1(d) do not apply when the record documents any of the following: progressive motor weakness; bowel or bladder dysfunction or saddle anesthesia; or suspected cancer, infection, or fracture.

3.3 Repeat imaging. Repeat MRI within 12 months requires a documented change in symptoms or examination findings.

4. Documentation

Acceptable documentation includes office notes, physical therapy evaluations, progress and discharge notes, attendance logs, and signed home exercise logs.

5. Not covered

MRI requested only for patient reassurance or for work clearance without the criteria above.